



NICARAGUA

Capital city: Managua
Area: 43,278 sq miles (129,494 sq km)
Population: 5,500,000
Official language: Spanish
Major religions: Christian 97%, other 3%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Gold córdoba
Adult literacy rate: 77%
Life expectancy: 69 years
People per doctor: 1,429
Televisions: 190 per 1,000 people

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SOMETIMES CALLED “the land of lakes and volcanoes,” Nicaragua is a beautiful country. It could also be one of the richest in Central America, but its recent history has been as violent as its earthquakes, and the economy has been thrown into chaos by past political events. The economy is mainly based on agriculture, with fishing along the coasts, but Nicaragua also has large deposits of minerals, including copper and gold, which are mined for export. The country has a young population, with more than half the people under the age of 15.



SANDINISTA REVOLUTION

For over 40 years, the Somoza family ruled Nicaragua as a dictatorship. But in 1979, rebels took control and formed the left-wing Sandinista government. They provided better health care, and set up a program of taking land from the rich and giving it to peasants. However, they were opposed by the Contras, anti-Sandinista forces backed by the United States, and thousands lost their lives in fighting during the next decade. In 1990 the Sandinistas lost the elections, but have retained their popularity among the poor.

FAMILY LIFE

Extended families are common in Nicaragua. Parents and children often live with their grandparents under one roof. Until 1979, more than half the population could not read or write. Under the Sandinistas, a literacy campaign was set up, and newly trained teachers, many of them women, were sent into rural areas to teach reading and writing. Within just a few months, literacy levels rose to 87 percent. However, when the Sandinistas lost power, the campaign faded and reading levels dropped again.

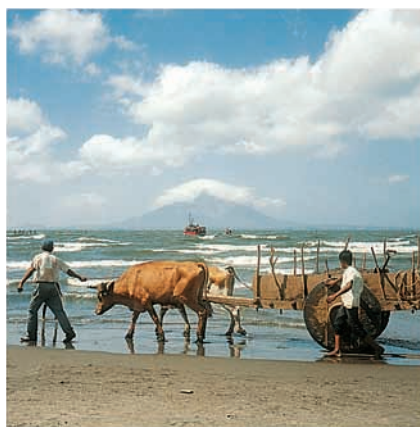


Overcrowding is a problem, and large families are often crammed into very small living spaces.



LIVING DANGEROUSLY

Most of Nicaragua's population lives on the Pacific coast, where many of the major cities are located. There are active volcanoes here, but earthquakes are the most serious danger. In 1972, the country's capital, Managua, was nearly destroyed by an earthquake that killed more than 6,000 people and left 300,000 homeless. In 1998, powerful Hurricane Mitch devastated Nicaragua's east coast, killing at least 3,800 people and causing damage estimated at \$1 billion.



Lake Nicaragua is named after Nicarao, an ancient Indian chief whose people lived by the lake.

FARMING THE LAND

The fertile volcanic soil near the Pacific coast forms the main farming region of Nicaragua. Corn (shown growing here), beans, and sorghum are the main food crops, and are harvested twice a year. Coffee, cotton, and bananas are also important export crops.



The corn ear, or cob, needs plenty of sunshine to grow and ripen.

Corn kernels are ground into flour and used to make tortillas, a type of pancake.

LAKE NICARAGUA

The west of the country is dominated by Lake Nicaragua, the largest lake in Central America. It is also the only freshwater lake in the world to contain sea fish, including sharks and swordfish. Scientists now think that sharks find their way to the lake by swimming up the San Juan River from the Caribbean Sea.

Find out more

LITERACY: 277

POLITICAL SYSTEMS: 270-271

POPULATION GROWTH: 43

VOLCANOES & EARTHQUAKES: 13